



A MOTORCYCLE cruises a portion of Highway 101 south of Crescent City shored up by a retaining wall. MIKE ZACCHINO For The Times

Highway is lifeline — and deadly

DEL NORTE COUNTY, Calif. — In March 1972, Kurt Stremberg's parents gave him a predawn ride from their house in northwest California to his friend's home in the tiny town of Klamath, about 20 miles south of Crescent City on Highway 101.

Stremberg, then 24, and his buddy were going to hitch a ride on a log truck bound for San Francisco, catch a flight to Europe and see the world.

His parents, Edwin and Aili Stremberg, said a quick goodbye, then started driving home. It was still dark. And raining hard.

In the few minutes it had taken to drop their son off, a landslide-plagued portion of the highway — ominously named Last Chance Grade — had crumbled. The Strembergs' Ford sedan went over the cliff, killing

\$2-billion tunnel is proposed to bypass slide-prone cliffs of the 101 in the state's far north

BY HAILEY BRANSON-POTTS



AN ARTIST'S vision of the tunnel. Highway 101 links Crescent City with the rest of California. California Department of Transportation

them both.

For decades, residents of California's remote northwest corner have been pleading with government officials to do something about Last Chance Grade, an eroding, three-mile stretch of highway hugging the fog-shrouded cliffs between the redwood forest and the Pacific Ocean.

It is a critical thoroughfare — the only viable route linking Crescent City, a tsunami-prone town of 6,200 people, with neighboring Humboldt County and the rest of the state.

But 53 years after the Strembergs' death, the two-lane road is still perilous. Perched atop four active landslides, its pavement warped and cracked by constant land movement, Last Chance Grade is so unstable that it was reduced to one-

Amid COVID wave, a mask push

Urging by county health officials comes as high coronavirus levels are detected.

BY RONG-GONG LIN II

A COVID wave is washing over California, with the state seeing continued increases in the number of newly confirmed cases and hospitalizations as some officials urged the public to take greater precautions.

The extent of the recent increases has prompted some county-level health officials to recommend that residents once again consider wearing masks in indoor public settings, at least until transmission has declined.

California currently has "high" coronavirus levels in sewage, according to the U.S. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention. And increases are being seen across the Golden State, from Los Angeles County to the San Francisco Bay Area to areas around the state capital.

The CDC estimates that coronavirus infections are either "growing" or "likely growing" in 30 states, including California.

"California is experiencing a summer COVID wave," said Dr. Aimee Sisson, the health officer in Yolo County, just west of Sacramento.

The rate at which coronavirus lab tests are coming back positive also continues to climb. For the week that ended Aug. 23, 12.07% of tests across the state came back positive, up from a rate of 6.03% for the week that ended July 26.

Similar leaps in rates [See COVID, A7]

Scientists decry U.S. climate report

85 researchers repudiate review questioning global warming's severity

BY HAYLEY SMITH

Dozens of the world's leading climate researchers on Tuesday publicly rebuked a hastily assembled report from the Trump administration that questions the severity of global warming — marking one of the strongest repudiations yet of the president's efforts to downplay climate change.

In a withering 459-page document, more than 85 scientists denounced the Department of Energy's July report as biased, error-ridden and unfit for guiding policy.

The report "fails to ad-

equately represent the current scientific understanding of climate change," they wrote. The authors include veterans in atmospheric science, physics, ecology, forecast modeling and several other fields at universities, think tanks and research institutions in the United States and abroad.

Titled "A Critical Review of Impacts of Greenhouse Gas Emissions on the U.S. Climate," the report was written by five researchers selected by U.S. Energy Secretary Chris Wright. It was published after the White House dismissed more than 400 scientists working on the sixth National Climate As-

essment and shut down the website that housed the previous assessments.

The Environmental Protection Agency leaned on the Energy Department report in its hotly contested proposal to repeal the endangerment finding, a landmark 2009 determination affirming that planet-warming greenhouse gases pose a threat to human health and the environment. The finding is the basis of many federal climate efforts.

Among its controversial conclusions, the Energy Department report determines that carbon dioxide-induced warming "might be less damaging economically

than commonly believed," and that "aggressive mitigation policies" — such as those designed to curb the use of fossil fuels — "could prove more detrimental than beneficial."

"The purpose of this report is to restore an open and transparent dialogue around climate science," department spokesman Ben Dietterich said in a statement to The Times on Tuesday.

But the authors of the rebuttal say the report misrepresents evidence, relies on discredited research and fails to follow the peer review process typically expected of [See Climate, A8]

Booster says he paid prep players' parents

He admits securing transfers for three L.A.-area campuses' football programs.

BY ERIC SONDHEIMER

Brett Steigh, a 1992 Narbonne High graduate, booster, local businessman and gambler, claims he violated City and Southern Section rules by paying parents of high school football players to help level the playing field.

Steigh said during a Monday night appearance on the "Fattal Factor" podcast that he paid parents to secure transfers for Narbonne and St. Bernard before currently "helping" Bishop Montgomery. Narbonne in Harbor City is part of the Los Angeles Unified School District, while the Archdiocese of Los Angeles operates St. Bernard in Playa del Rey

and Bishop Montgomery in Torrance.

Although name, image and likeness policies allow for payment of players, recruiting transfer athletes and paying their parents as much as \$50,000 remains a violation of the California Interscholastic Federation's undue influence rules.

"I ain't doing nothing that others aren't doing," Steigh said, alleging Orange County private schools, including national powerhouse Mater Dei, paid to secure transfer players.

A Mater Dei spokesperson has not yet responded to a request for comment in response to the allegation.

Steigh said he recruited players in 2018 and 2024 to Narbonne without the knowledge of the head coaches while paying parents to move. Both times, Narbonne was sanctioned by the City Section for rule violations. [See Football, A7]



AFGHAN QUAKE DEATHS TOP 1,400 An injured person is carried to a military helicopter after the major tremor in eastern Afghanistan this week. Death toll may still rise. WORLD, A3

Heat wave gives way to storms
Lightning combined with winds and high temperatures raises fire risks. CALIFORNIA, B1

Quarterbacks ready for season
Times columnists offer their takes on Chargers' Herbert and Rams' Stafford. SPORTS, B10

Weather
Mostly sunny; warm. L.A. Basin: 90/68. B6

